

Practice Paper 16 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Rehearsed sentence has lost something

1 mark for understanding that **over-rehearsal** has stripped the sentence of **freshness / sincerity / genuine feeling**.

1 mark for understanding that a sentence spoken to real children for the **first time** still carries that quality of **aliveness / spontaneity / real meaning**.

Sample answer: She means that, by repeating the sentence so many times, it has become **mechanical and lifeless**, whereas a sentence said for the **first time** to a real audience still carries the **genuine warmth and nervousness** that makes it feel real.

Q2. [2] — Two details showing anxiety

1 mark each for any two of:

- Her file was “clamped against my chest like a shield” — suggesting she is **defending herself**.
- Her new shoes were “already biting at my heels” — a hint that she has **over-prepared / fussed** about appearance.
- She “paused” outside the door before entering.
- She “took a breath that did not quite fill [her] lungs” — physical sign of nerves.
- She had to “fix” her smile — implying it was not natural.

Reject: “the brisk confidence of a teacher” — this is what she was **trying** to appear, not anxiety.

Q3. [2] — “Connoisseurs of new teachers”

1 mark for understanding **connoisseurs** — **experts**, people who **judge with practised skill**.

1 mark for understanding that the children have **seen many new teachers** before and have learned how to **size them up quickly** — they are **experienced judges**, not innocent novices.

Q4. [2] — Effect of three short sentences

1 mark — The clipped, **short sentences** slow the pace and make each **small action** (crossing, setting down the file, turning) feel **deliberate and heavy**.

1 mark — The structure mimics the narrator’s **tense, step-by-step focus**, building **suspense** before the moment when she opens her mouth. (Also accept: it conveys her **attempt to stay in control** / a **staccato, nervous rhythm**.)

Q5. [2] — Ink climbing blotting paper

1 mark — The comparison is a **simile** / vivid image: blotting paper **absorbs ink slowly and visibly**, the colour spreading upwards.

1 mark — This helps the reader picture her blush as something **slow, uncontrollable**, and **spreading visibly across her skin** — emphasising how exposed and helpless she feels.

Q6. [2] — Sarah’s “unselfconscious kindness”

(a) **[1]: Unselfconscious** means Sarah is **not embarrassed** / not worrying about how she looks. She helps the teacher **naturally and without hesitation**, because she has not yet learned to be shy about offering help.

(b) **[1]:** It suggests that adults, **unlike children**, are expected to **cope alone** / pretend not to need help; adulthood involves **pride** and a **refusal to admit weakness**.

Q7. [2] — Two details showing the shift

1 mark each for any two of:

- The boy in the second row “was no longer whispering” — the mockery has stopped.
- Sarah was “sitting very straight, as though she had been entrusted with something important” — the child feels valued.
- The narrator’s handwriting was “legible”, surprising her — her physical panic has subsided.
- The narrator looked at thirty faces, “and they looked back” — there is now mutual attention / connection.
- She realises they were “not, after all, [her] enemies” — her perception of the room has changed.

Q8. [1] — “Relief that almost made my eyes water”

1 mark — It shows that she had been **extremely anxious** / **on the edge of panic** beforehand; the sudden release of that tension is **so overwhelming** that it almost moves her to tears.

Q9. [2] — “Clumsier, truer thing”

1 mark — **Clumsier:** what she actually said was **unpolished, hesitant, unrehearsed** — not as smooth as her practised opening.

1 mark — **Truer:** it was **honest** / it admitted she was new and nervous, so it **connected with the children** in a way the rehearsed speech could not have.

Q10. [2] — The marker as symbol

1 mark — It symbolises the **help she received** from Sarah / from a child — a **reminder of human kindness** offered at a vulnerable moment.

1 mark — It symbolises a **humbler view of teaching**: she keeps it where she sees it every day to remind herself that a teacher is not someone who knows everything but someone who is **willing to be helped**. (Accept: it symbolises her **first morning** and the lesson it taught her.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, humble, grateful, wise, quietly affectionate**. (Reject: **bitter, regretful, sad** — these miss the warm, accepting quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Languages “passed down at kitchen tables”

1 mark for understanding that languages survive through **everyday, informal use within families and communities** — not through formal teaching.

1 mark for understanding that small, ordinary interactions (jokes, conversations between generations) are the **real mechanism** by which a language is **transmitted from parent or grandparent to child**.

Q13. [2] — Why the writer poses the question

1 mark — He is **anticipating the reader’s likely objection** — that the loss of a dialect does not really matter if the speakers can already use bigger languages.

1 mark — He raises it so that he can **answer it** / refute it in the same paragraph, by showing that a language is not just a substitute for another but a **unique way of seeing the world**.

Q14. [2] — Why the loss of the Mon tense matters

1 mark — The tense allows speakers to refer to **actions completed before they were born** — a feature not easily expressed in other languages.

1 mark — When the tense dies, the **particular way of thinking about memory, time and inheritance** that it makes possible **dies with it** — so what is lost is not only a word but a way of **understanding the world**.

Reject answers that simply lift “a feature that quietly reshapes how its speakers think about memory and inheritance”.

Q15. [2] — Two pressures from schooling and society

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Schools teach in a single national or international language**, not in small dialects.
- **Examinations** are conducted in that dominant language.
- **Jobs are advertised** in that language, so career prospects favour it.
- **Films and pop music** are produced in it, so cultural prestige sits with it.
- Parents who try to raise children in a dialect must work **against every signal society sends** about which language matters.

Q16. [1] — Inverted commas around “matters”

1 mark — The inverted commas signal that the writer does **not personally agree** with this judgement / he is using the word **ironically**. He is reporting **society’s view** that only certain languages are important, while **implying that this view is wrong or unjust**.

Q17. [2] — What revival projects more modestly achieve

1 mark — They create a generation that **knows the dialect exists** / is **aware** of its own linguistic heritage.

1 mark — This **awareness** is itself an important first step, because a dialect cannot be revived if young people do not even know it is there to be saved.

Reject answers that simply lift “a generation that knows its dialect exists”.

Q18. [2] — Two opposite effects of technology

1 mark — **Harmful effect:** social-media feeds are **dominated by a few major languages**, which **crowds out smaller dialects** from young people’s daily attention.

1 mark — **Helpful effect:** the same platforms allow communities to **create free online dictionaries, record elders, and share recordings widely** — preserving languages that previously had no written form.

Reject lifts of “double-edged” without explanation.

Q19. [2] — “None of this should be mistaken for victory”

1 mark — **Tone:** cautionary / sober / realistic / sobering. (Also accept: measured, honest.)

1 mark — He adopts it to **check the optimism** of the previous paragraph and to **remind the reader** that revival successes are **small exceptions** against a much larger pattern of loss.

Q20. [1] — Why it is unfair to expect families to act alone

1 mark — Because the **whole of society benefits** from linguistic diversity, but only the individual **family bears the economic cost** of raising a child in a less useful language — that burden ought to be **shared**. (Accept: economic logic punishes families who choose small tongues.)

Q21. [2] — Effect of the final contrast

1 mark — The contrast between being **killed by an enemy** and **dying through ordinary, everyday choices** is **striking and surprising** — it forces the reader to see language loss not as a dramatic event but as the **sum of small, blameless decisions**.

1 mark — It is also **empowering**: if a language dies through ordinary choices, then ordinary people **also have the power to keep it alive** through equally small, daily choices — giving the article a hopeful ending.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Pressures causing dialect loss (Paragraph 3):

1. **Formal schooling** takes place in a single national or international language.
2. **Examinations and jobs** are conducted and advertised in that dominant language, so families face **economic pressure** to abandon dialects.
3. **Films and pop music** are produced in the dominant language, lending it cultural prestige.
4. The result is a **generational gap**: children understand grandparents’ dialect but cannot pass it to their own children.

Revival efforts (Paragraphs 4–5):

5. **Community classes, children’s books, and pop songs** are being produced in revived dialects (e.g. Kristang).
6. **Bilingual signage** and **school instruction** in indigenous tongues alongside national languages.
7. **Online dictionaries and digital archives** — often crowdsourced — preserve dialects that previously had no written form.
8. **Ordinary families** can now **record elders, upload folk stories, and add subtitles** using mobile phones and free platforms.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Asian dialects are disappearing because schools, examinations and employment all use one dominant language, while films and music reinforce its prestige; children therefore grow up understanding their elders but unable to speak the dialect back. Against this, enthusiasts run free classes, write storybooks and pop songs, and persuade governments to include local tongues in schools and signage. Free online dictionaries, family phone recordings, and crowdsourced archives now preserve tongues that previously had no written form.

Length count: 78 words from “Asian” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —